



MONTHLY UPDATE

South Africa: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-04 · 14 systems and instruments tracked, 12 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-04 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Two spectrum instruments were gazetted, the national artificial-intelligence policy changed from a rule-making instrument to a guidance one, and the Western Cape High Court struck down part of the birth-registration regulations. On delivery, a Public Service Commission investigation found [more than R2bn in irregular expenditure](#) at the State Information Technology Agency, which was [given 30 days to produce a recovery plan](#). Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded the single citizen application at [production-ready pilot](#), dated the next milestones to September 2026 and stated that progress had been uneven.

Infrastructure

The [National Radio Frequency Plan 2026](#), approved by the minister on 2 July, was gazetted on 24 July and realigns the allocation table from 8.3kHz to 3,000GHz to the ITU Radio Regulations and to the SADC and African Telecommunications Union plans. The [IMT Roadmap 2026](#) was published for consultation the same day; its tables record 794MHz assigned to licensees and 18,831MHz still to be assigned. The regulator's accompanying statement of an increase from 850MHz to at least 18,588MHz by 2030, and of a 215% rise in high-demand spectrum, does not appear in the gazetted text; the two accounts have not been reconciled. Allocation of the 6GHz band was [deferred pending a feasibility study](#).

Herotel, a domestic provider with more than 350,000 customers, was [named Amazon Leo's South African distributor](#) for a 2027 launch. Starlink [began service in its 27th African country](#) and remains unlicensed in South Africa; the department told Parliament its draft satellite policy direction was ["of general application and not directed at any specific operator"](#). The state-backed [BrainSAT](#) venture launched on Emirati infrastructure.

Cape Town's municipal planning tribunal [approved two Equinix data centres](#) over objections from three civil-society organisations; the application disclosed neither water nor electricity demand, both deferred to the site development plan. Reuters put the planned load at about 170MW. NTT Data South Africa confirmed it had [sold seven facilities and leased them back](#). Google held its first African cloud summit in Johannesburg and announced an Eastern Cape exchange port; the President welcomed hyperscaler commitments while [stating that government is building its own cloud through the CSIR](#).

Digital public infrastructure

Absa [joined the bank-branch smart identity channel](#), which the department put at 296 branches and more than 385,000 applications in four months; Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report gave 203,887 applications across 171 branches. The reference periods differ and the figures have not been reconciled. Mobile operators and the justice department agreed a framework to [replace document presentation in SIM registration with real-time departmental verification](#).

Home Affairs reported [377,060 identity numbers still blocked](#) and stated it could not trace approximately 400,000 of those affected, against a court deadline extended to March 2027. On 29 July the Western Cape High Court [held four categories of exclusion in the birth-registration regulations unconstitutional](#), allowing 18 months for amendment and holding that the orders required no Constitutional Court confirmation.

Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded an update under way to the [Minimum Interoperability Standards and the Government-Wide Enterprise Architecture](#), with an update due September 2026. The same report recorded the Payments Ecosystem Modernisation programme moving beyond conceptual design into active development of a payment credential, wallet, governance and trust capabilities, with testing against government use cases dated November 2026. Nothing held states how that rail relates to the bank-API rails below.

On 3 August the single citizen application was reported as a [production-ready pilot](#), its first credential use case a digital matric certificate built with Umalusi, with the verification approach in testing.

The Reserve Bank gazetted a [national interoperable payment code standard](#), with PayShap the first rail to adopt it. Ozow launched a shared [bank application-programming-interface rail with FNB and RMB](#), its fourth such arrangement, and Pepkor announced a [R21.3bn merger of Flash and Shop2Shop](#), subject to approval.

Governance and regulation

The Electronic Communications Amendment Bill was published, [exempting community networks from licensing](#) and mandating spectrum sharing; submissions close on 21 August. The minister [backed the regulator](#) in the review application brought by the two largest mobile operators against the data bundle roll-over rules. The Angolan kwanza became the [second settlement currency on the SADC real-time system](#), the first addition since 2013. Afreximbank and the Industrial Development Corporation signed a three-year memorandum against an [\\$8bn envelope](#); no pipeline, schedule or risk split was disclosed.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

The Department of Communications and Digital Technologies stated on 29 July that the redrafted national AI policy [will issue guidelines rather than prescribe rules](#), and that the seven institutions proposed in the withdrawn draft are being reconsidered; cabinet consideration is targeted for November 2026, with January 2027 as fallback. On 31 July the chair of Parliament's communications portfolio committee stated her [opposition to creating new AI regulators](#).

The Prudential Authority's 2025/26 report, reported on 16 July, [embeds AI, cloud, cyber and data-offshoring into bank supervision](#) and records a first nationwide AI-adoption survey naming regulatory uncertainty, AI skills and governance as the barriers. A dedicated framework is expected in 2026; none is published.

The Labour Court [stayed disciplinary proceedings](#) against three municipal employees on prima facie evidence that a ruling relied on authorities that do not exist. SARS disclosed that [100% of verification cases and 88.41% of complex audits](#) are selected by automated risk assessment. Home Affairs reported that its electronic travel authorisation had [refused more than 5,500 travellers](#) since October 2025. Huawei reported [1,400 local partners accounting for 94.7% of its local revenue](#) at its Sandton partner event, where South Africa's founding membership of the China-led World AI Cooperation Organisation was noted; the figures are company-reported.

Inclusion, capacity and finance

The South African Social Security Agency [set 350,000 grant reviews for 2026/27](#) against a projected R1.5bn saving, while beneficiaries flagged from September 2025 [reported continued non-payment](#). An account of the digitalised grants system published on 25 July set out the [bank-account means test applied across eight grants](#), which remains in operation under appeal, with the Supreme Court of Appeal hearing set for 25 August 2026. Gold Cards were confirmed to [cease functioning after 31 August](#); the position of beneficiaries who miss the deadline was not stated. The information technology sector education and training authority was [referred for a governance assessment](#), and Telkom committed [R100m to an AI institute](#).

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